

"Oh, don't mind that," Elizabeth explains. "That's from the chickens I was keeping for food. Now, with Dead-Eye gone, I was hoping to be able to recruit more people to help get eyes out there to look for the Devourer. Can we count on you? I would pay handsomely." She produces a sack of gold coins, which Hazel happily accepts.

"Thank you so much for your help," Elizabeth says. "Now, if there's any assistance or help you need, please, feel free to ask. Rest up here if you need to. I extend my hospitality to you brave adventurers." The Party thank her for her hospitality.

Lady In Cruel Confine

Hazel takes the opportunity to head out the cave and up the stairs, visiting the petrified tree.

Hazel. You are standing in front of the Tree. The towering oak stares down at you. Through gaps in the bark, you can see, trapped in orange amber, is a beautiful elf with her hands outstretched. Behind her, you see a complicated machine of some kind.



As you step up, preparing to cast *Speak with Plants*, you feel your backpack shake violently. The *Grimoire of Saleander* flies out from the backpack and lands in your hands, flipping quickly to the poem inscribed so long ago.

You hear a voice ring out from inside your head.

"Wait!"

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel realizes that the *Death Rider Engine* is mid-explosion. On a successful DC 20 check, Hazel realizes that the explosion is still ongoing, just slowed.

"What are you doing?!" Alisandra demands. She speaks telepathically with the cleric, afraid that she was about to do something that might worsen the precarious situation.

"Please, no magic around here," She insists. "This is the *Death Rider Engine*. It was constructed centuries ago by Jarlan the Irresponsible and Ras Nsi, in their misguided attempt to destroy Raya. They had brought the prototype here to siphon off divine energy from Ubtao and raise an army of the dead."

"And then you stopped them," Hazel remembers.

"Yes. We, the barae of Mezro, immortal protectors chosen by Ubtao, came to stop them. The two of them refused to listen to reason, and the argument got out of hand. It turned into an all out brawl. Hoping to shut it down, Arthur shot an arrow at it. Unfortunately, it damaged the Engine, which began to melt down. It released a powerful pulse of necromantic energy across the continent and began reviving the dead."

"What happened to Jarlan?" Hazel asks.

"The blast killed him, and sent Ras Nsi into the basin below. With no other means to stop it, I channelled my magic to seal myself and the Engine away in arboreal amber. I alone have been the living seal protecting the continent. Problem is, this did not stop the process completely, but merely slowed it down. Time passes differently in the amber; a second is a decade out there. I'm afraid we do not have long. If nothing is done to stop the meltdown, the blast would eventually rip through the amber and cause not only untold destruction across the continent, but severely destroy the Veil between Life and Death."

Hazel looks down at her book, and sees that the line "Strike the Heart, Sever the Vine" in her poem is glowing exceptionally brightly, as if bolded. She realizes that *Entropy's Bloom*, the axe with Arthur, will likely break the resin and free Alisandra and the *Death Rider Engine*.

“How long do you expect we would have to stop the meltdown, once we freed you?” Hazel asks.

“Maybe a couple of seconds,” Alisandra replies.

“And the axe,” Hazel asks. “It’s with Arthur? Where is he?”

“My love has headed off to Port M’Kaze,” Alisandra says. “He told me he is petitioning the Ytepka Society to mount an expedition to Jarlan’s Laboratory and reclaim the blueprints to try and disable the Engine. He has been gone for two tendays.”

Hazel grows suspicious at the comment. She wonders where could Arthur possibly be, given that him and Dragonbait had set off much earlier than them.

“We know somebody at the Laboratory right now,” Hazel assures her. “We’ll find Arthur and then come and help you.”

Alisandra thanks the cleric, who promptly returns downstairs.

The Shadowmantle Twins

Downstairs, while Hazel is conversing with Alisandra, Salazar and Vilde make small talk with Elizabeth Shadowmantle. Wang Lei, Wukong and Raphael takes a look around the lair.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a DC 15, they see Grace Shadowmantle. On a DC 20, they find a small scale model of the *Death Rider Engine*. Beside it is a stone shaped like a mouth.

In the corner of the room, skulking in the darkness, you see a pale and gaunt figure milling about. She has on a tattered, dark red blouse, with wide, big eyes. She has black lips and long, thin, dark hair with a shock of white through her bangs, pulled up in a half-bun of some kind. Black bile drips from her fingers, as the figure smiles at you.

“Please don’t mind her,” Elizabeth says. “That is my sister, Grace.”

The figure turns back, and picks up a saw. She slaps what looks like a green, humanoid arm of some kind on the chopping block and begins slicing into it.

Hazel reappears, using Common Sign Language to communicate to Vilde that there is something weird afoot. She shares that Alisandra seems unaware that Elizabeth is occupying the Heart, and that Arthur seems to be the rightful owner.





Vilde shoots Raphael a look, who initiates *Rary's Telepathic Bond* for the Party to communicate. Hazel relays all that she has learnt, and suggests that they evict the squatters. As the Party deliberates on the matter, Salazar and Vilde make small talk with Elizabeth to make sure she does not sense anything amiss.

You see green flames explode into existence as three Red Wizards step up. They come up to Elizabeth and bow. A male wizard, also bald, reports that "Solena is dead."

"Bashed in by a mace," another one continued.

A look of rage passes over Elizabeth's face. She turns back to the group, and says, "I'm sorry, my new friends. We have a problem and would appreciate some privacy." Her eyes glow blue as another *Arcane Gate* materialises in front of all of you.

"Feel free to come back anytime you're in the area," She tosses you, Raphael, a Sending stone. "Your aid in locating the Devourer is much appreciated."

Deciding to trust Hazel's instincts, Salazar takes the opportunity to cast *Wall of Ice*.

As he does so, two of the Red Wizards fire *Counterspells* and slap his spell out of the air. Wang Lei's pauldron glows with a malevolent blue light as he phases out of reality. He flits through Grace, who is still tending to her work in the dark alcove.

Openly hostile, Elizabeth casts *Cloudkill*. Noxious, yellow smog explodes into existence around Thaisha, Vilde, Hazel and Salazar. Choking and coughing, the toxic smog pours into their lungs and burns their insides.

Hazel summons her duplicate. The duplicate bounds forward, rushing up to Elizabeth. Her eyes glow golden as she casts *Spirit Guardians*, summoning her deity's radiant defenders to smite Elizabeth.

Enlarging his *Jingubang*, Wukong races forward. He strikes Elizabeth squarely in the chest, knocking the wind out of her lungs. Raphael seizes the opportunity to create distance, leaping away as he opens a gateway to the dark between the stars. A sphere of darkness and bitter cold appears at the centre of the room as air begins to be rapidly sucked into it. Black tentacles lash out from the sphere, grabbing people around.

Taking advantage of the darkness, Salazar once again casts *Wall of Ice*. Jagged ice shards burst forth from the ground, knocking all four Red Wizards into a makeshift prison.

Wang Lei pulls out his symbol of Caishenye and tries to *Control Undead*. Grace resists the burning power of the oathbreaker, and snarls in response. With superhuman speed and her eyes still stinging from the gas, Vilde appears like a ghost behind Grace. With a flash, her scimitar slices through Grace's neck. Black bile pours out from the wound as her head fully swivels around, flashing a devilish grin.

Inside the *Wall of Ice*, the Red Wizards unleash a powerful *Fireball*. The flames wash over the ice shards, vaporising them in an instant.

Stumbling out of the toxic cloud, Thaisha casts *Guiding Bolt*. A blast of radiant energy sears Grace, who screams in pain.

In the dark, Elizabeth asks, "Raphael, where are you?" A shimmering lance of psychic power strikes out towards Raphael. He resists the strike, and just barely holds on to his concentration on the *Hunger of Hadar*.

Wanting to stop the fight, Hazel uses one of the spells Salazar helped tattooed on her. By the rabbit's head, the tattoo glows with a soft green light as a sphere of ice erupts from the ground, flash-freezing all three Red Wizards. Heat is sucked violently from their body as their blood turns to frost, leaving only three corpses entombed in clear rime ice.

Wukong moves out of the darkness, trying to avoid the tentacles. He sees Wang Lei and Vilde in combat with Grace, declares "Die, demon!" The simian somersaults in the air and strikes Grace square in the chest, crushing her ribcage and killing her.

Still reeling from the psychic assault, Raphael stumbles over to a locked chest. He stays there for a moment, catching his breath.

With Grace dealt with, Wang Lei rushes forward into the *Hunger of Hadar*. His eyes, now two pinpricks of dark light, hunt for Elizabeth.

"Dear Hazel, you must be strong," Elizabeth taunts. "You've killed three of my wizards!" The Red Wizard casts another *Raulothim's Psychic Lance*, finding her mark in the cleric this time. The psychic blast strikes Hazel, breaking her concentration on the *Wall of Ice*. The cleric throws a red *Chanter's Egg* into the dark, releasing a powerful explosion muffled by darkness of the *Hunger of Hadar*.

"There you are," Wang Lei seethes. His gauntlets glow with malevolent green light as Wang Lei fires three powerful blasts from his eyes, pulverising Elizabeth. The lich screams in pain.

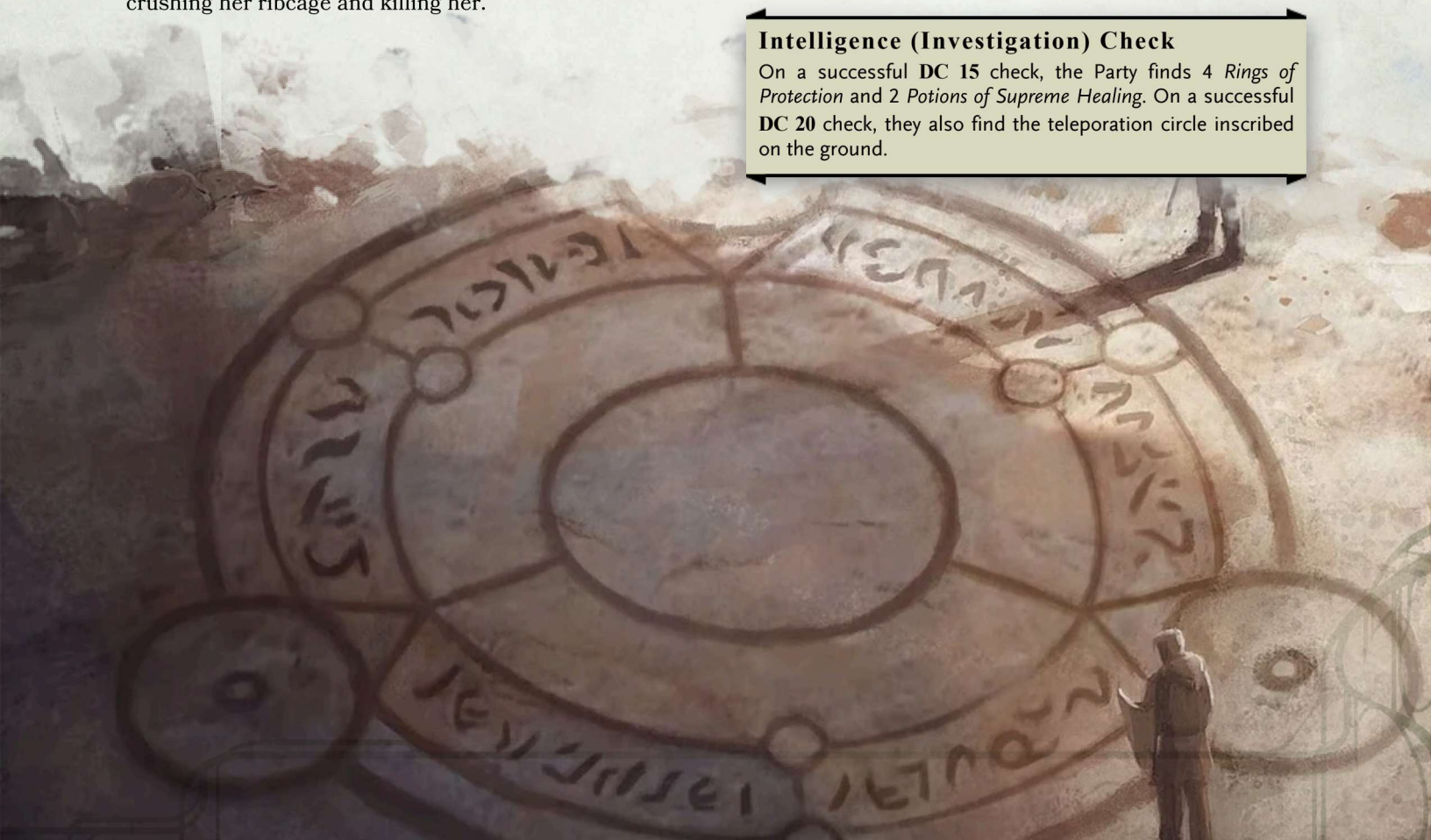
Following her cries, Wukong races in. His eyes burn with a divine fire as he activates his *Truesight*. "Die, demon!" He declares once more as he unleashes another *Guiding Bolt*.

The lich casts *Shield*. Her forcefield forms a second too late as the radiant blast incinerates her, leaving her only screams to die out with divine flame.

Vilde closes distance with Raphael, checking on him while Thaisha casts *Healing Word* on Hazel. "Everyone all right?"

Intelligence (Investigation) Check

On a successful **DC 15** check, the Party finds 4 *Rings of Protection* and 2 *Potions of Supreme Healing*. On a successful **DC 20** check, they also find the teleporation circle inscribed on the ground.



"There's no phylactery here," Wang Lei points out.

"I thought Grace was Elizabeth's phylactery?" Raphael asks.

"No, no," Salazar explains. "It is usually a jar of some kind. Elizabeth made Grace a lich by killing their father, and then sealed her soul into a jar."

"Looks like it isn't here," Vilde points out.

"That's bad news," Salazar continued. "It means they can come back to life, wherever their phylactery is at."

"Then we should leave," Wang Lei says. "Or at least, make sure they cannot return."

The Party inspects the teleportation circle. Salazar explains the magic behind teleporationg circles, explaining that it is similar to the Webway of Ubtao and can only be created by powerful conjurers. He points out the sigil sequence - a string of runes arranged in a particular pattern - and that these can be used to travel to a different teleportation circle.

While Wang Lei, Vilde and Salazar study the circle and discuss a potential way to seal off the teleportation circle, Raphael and Hazel head upstairs.

Hazel updates Alisandra about what happened, and asks about Yandala. Alisandra replies that "she never had a daughter, but would not be surprised if Arthur had one, given his long life adventuring." She also shares that Arthur had yet to return, which is again surprising to Hazel given that they had left before the Party.

Raphael takes a look around the basin, trying to spot possible landmarks. He spies a suspended wooden vessel in the treeline.

"How would Arthur come up? Can he fly?" Hazel asks.

"Oh, no," Alisandra explains. "There's a Webway portal, you see. Right over there." Hazel calls Raphael over, and they examine a second, smaller tree on the upper floor of the *Heart*. Built into the oak is a massive stone slab, which they recognize is another Webway portal.

Rejoining the group, the pair share what they found upstairs.

"Another way down, perhaps," Raphael suggests.

"But we don't know where it leads to," Wang Lei points out.

"We only have the address paths of two other Webway portals," Salazar shares. "The one beneath the crypts in the Church of Caishenye, and the one in Wakanga's house. There must be another one somewhere down in the basin below where Arthur and Dragonbait were heading to so they could come up."

After much discussion, the Party elects to contact Ayo and Mason, who are downstairs in the basin. "With any luck," Wang Lei points out, "They would be able to track down Arthur and find their way to the Webway portal he used to come up."

Poisoned

As the Party sends a message to Ayo, asking her to find Arthur and thus another way to safely come down, they receive a very different response.

"We have a different problem," Ayo's voice rings out the Sending Stone. "Duo, he's hurt."

The warning that her friend is hurt sends a shot of panic through Hazel. The Party decides to take the fast way down: Thaisha volunteers to wildshape into a falcon and carry the cleric to Ayo, Mason, Princess and Duo, while the rest jump off the Heart and have Salazar slow the two-hundred foot fall with *Featherfall*.

As you approach, you see the nature of the emergency: collapsed on his side, with his tongue splayed out of its beak is Duo. His eyes are shut as he draws soft, pained breaths.

"It's the hag's brew," Ayo explains. "He must be cursed somehow."

Wisdom (Medicine) Check

On a successful **DC 15** check, Hazel feels a potent wave of fey energy residing in Duo. She realizes that a spider-like parasite has wrapped its tendrils around the owlbear's heart, and is tightly constricting it.

"A *Remove Curse* spell won't work," Hazel shares. "This is because of the Hag."

"Oh!" Ayo exclaims. "There's a simple solution for that. A potion called *Hag's Bane*." The guide rushes off to her backpack and begins searching frantically. "I should have a bottle here somewhere..."

As the search continues, the rest of the Party stumbles out of the lake, having swam the length of the basin.

As the rest of you come up, you see that Mason and Ayo have set up camp for you guys by the edge of the river leading into the basin. Your Commanders' Tent has been laid out inside a massive triceratops skeleton.



Walking in, Wang Lei, you see a tall plant with three, large, brightly-colored flowers at the top: one orange, one red, and one yellow. The flowers seem to be vibrating and shaking.

“Uh, what is that?” Wang Lei asks.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a DC 15, the Party is not surprised. On a DC 20, the Party realizes that there are multiples of such plants surrounding them, all of who appear to be ever so slightly moving closer and closer.

With a hiss, an orange flower blasts a spray of orange sap onto your face.